2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante Melissa Rojas

Grade / Grado 203

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna Yesenia Alvarez

School / Escuela Rachel Carson

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Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- ○ Father / Padre
- ○ Grandfather / Abuelo
- ○ Stepdad / Padrasto
- ◉ Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

What makes a good Father-figure, is someone who cares for you and is always there for you when you need. Someone you can look up to and someone you can trust with all your heart. Someone who can take respondsibilties for you and always motivate you.

My mom is a good father-figure because she's always been by my side when i needed someone. She does put to much presure on me, because she believes i'll do good in life. She cares for me and my health, she notice when something is wrong with me or my siblings. I can always count on my mom because i know ahe going to be there for me when i have no friends, no job in the future, a family in the future and more. She helps me clean and cook and other things I need to learn when I get older. She's a good person, a good friend and a great mother, she always cooks and clean, and takes her time to do favors for others. Even though i can be hard on her i still love her and she's always taking the respondaiblities for my brother's bad behavior.She always has positive energy, even when she feels sad or needs to cry she puts a smile on her face for me. Even when my whole family is mad at me, she always takes my side and defends me every single time. I can tell her everything although when the conversation isnt serious we she jugdes but most of the times she does. A lot of people take advantage of her but she wont let anyone hurt any of her kids or family members. Although my father was never really there for me or in my life i consider my mom as a mother and father. Thats what makes my mom a good father-figure.

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

    1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.